Sarah Cole: A Type of Love Story

By Russell Banks

RON: Here is a scene in which I am the man and my friend Sarah Cole is the woman. I don't mind describing it now, because I'm a decade older and don't look the same now as I did then, and Sarah is dead. I was extremely handsome then. And I must tell you that Sarah was very homely. In fact, she was the homeliest woman I have ever known. Personally, I mean. I've *seen* a few women who were more unattractive than Sarah, but they were clearly freaks of nature or had been badly injured or had been victimized by some grotesque, disfiguring disease. Sarah, however, was quite normal, and I knew her well.

INTRODUCTION

There are those of us who think, "Beauty is in the eye of the beholder", or even, "it's what's on the inside that counts". But to be brutally honest . . . isn't that ***just*** *what we said to our overweight, uglier friends when we were in high school? In this selection, our handsome protagonist, Ron, reflects on a period in his life when he crossed paths with and possibly fell in love with homely, Sarah Cole. Can men see past a woman's looks? Do men ever form real relationships with unattractive women? Sometimes the truth itself is ugly.*

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EDUCATIONAL

RON: Around six o' clock on a Wednesday evening in late May a man enters a bar. Our man, Ron, is effortlessly attractive, a genetic wonder, tall, slender, symmetrical, and clean. His flaws: a small mole on the left corner of his square but not-too-prominent chin, a slight excess of blond hair on the tops of his tanned hands, and somewhat underdeveloped buttocks, only contribute to his beauty.. And he is nice, too, the consequence, perhaps, of his seeming not to know how beautiful he is. Ron

takes a seat at the bar, unfolds the evening paper in front of him, and orders a scotch and soda, with a twist.

He has got to the classified section, when the woman who will turn out to be Sarah Cole leaves a booth in the back and approaches him. She comes up from the side and sits next to him. She's wearing heavy, tan cowboy boots and a dark brown, suede cowboy hat, lumpy jeans and a yellow tee shirt that clings to her arms, breasts, and round belly like the skin of a sausage. Though he will later learn that she is thirty-eight years old, she looks older by about ten years, which makes her look twenty years older than **he** actually is.

SARAH: It's not bad here at the bar. *(looking around)* More light, anyhow. Whatcha readin'?

RON: Ron looks up from his paper with a slight smile on his lips, sees the face of a woman homelier than any he has ever seen or imagined before, and goes on smiling lightly. He feels himself falling into her tiny, slightly crossed, dark brown eyes, pulls himself back, and studies for a few seconds her mottled, pocked complexion, bulbous nose, loose mouth, twisted and gapped teeth, and heavy but receding chin. He casts a glance over her thatch of dun-colored hair and along her neck and throat, where acne burns against gray skin, and returns to her eyes, and again feels himself falling into her. *(To Sarah)* What did you say?

She knocks a mentholated cigarette from her pack, and Ron swiftly lights it. Blowing smoke from her large, wing-shaped nostrils, she speaks again. Her voice is thick and nasal, a chocolate-colored voice.

SARAH: I asked you whatcha readin', but I can see now." *(loud bark of a laugh)* The paper!

RON: *(laughing too)* The paper! *The Concord Monitor!*" *(to audience)* He is not hallucinating, he clearly sees what is before him and admits to himself that he is speaking to the most unattractive woman he has ever seen. He begins to ask questions of her, he

buys her a drink, he smiles, until soon it seems, even to him, that he is taking her and her life quite seriously. He learns her name, of course, and she volunteers the information that she spoke to him on a dare from one of the two women still sitting in the booth behind her. Sarah goes on telling him what he wants to know, about her job at the Rumford Press, about her divorced husband who was a bastard. She tells Ron about her three children. She speaks of her children with genuine tenderness and concern, and Ron is touched. *(to Sarah)* You're a nice woman. *(to audience)* He wonders about her husband. What kind of man would fall in love with Sarah Cole? *(Scene Break)*

Friday, and once again Ron appeared with his evening newspaper. After a few minutes Sarah was once again at his side. She talked more easily than she had the night before, and [Ron . . . . no . . . .] *(Shift to first person is intentional)* **I** listened as eagerly and carefully as I had before. I did not know how cruel this was. When you have never done a thing before and that thing is not simply and clearly right or wrong, you frequently do not know if it is a cruel thing, you just go ahead and do it, and maybe later you'll be able to determine whether you acted cruelly.

While we drank, Sarah told me that she hated her ex-husband because of the way he treated the children.

SARAH: He won't even write them a letter or anything. He won't call them on the phone, all he calls for is to bitch at me because I'm trying to get the state to take him to court so I can get some of the money he's s'posed to be paying for child support. And he won't even think to talk to the kids when he calls. Won't even ask about them.

RON: He sounds like a bastard.

SARAH: He is, he is. I don't know why I married him. Or stayed married. Fourteen years, for Christ's sake. He put a spell over me or something, I don't know. *(wistfully)* He wasn't what you'd call good-looking.

RON: *(to audience)* After her second drink, she decided she had to leave. Her children were at home, I left the place and drove straight to my apartment. One night several weeks later, Ron *(Shift to 3rd person is intentional)* meets Sarah at Osgood's, and after buying her three white Russians and drinking three scotches himself, he takes her back to his apartment.

I'm still the man in this story, and Sarah is still the woman, but I'm telling it this way because what I have to tell you now confuses me, embarrasses me, and makes me sad, and consequently, I'm likely to tell it falsely.

Ron unlocks the door to his apartment, walks in ahead of her, and flicks on the lamp beside the couch. *(to Sarah)* Come in, come in. *(to audience)* She steps timidly in and closes the door behind her. She removes her cowboy hat, then quickly puts it back on, crosses the living room, and plops down in a blond easy chair. *(to Sarah)* Would you like a drink?

SARAH: No . . . I guess not. *(not looking at Ron and visibly nervous)* I don't know. I don't know . . . I don't know.

RON: What? Change your mind? Seriously. Want me to fix you a white Russian?

SARAH: No.

RON: *(gently)* Are you scared? . . . . *I* am.

SARAH: Well, no, I'm not scared. *(silent beat)* You're scared? Of what? *(still avoiding eye contact)*

RON: Well . . . I don't do this all the time, you know. Bring home a woman I . . .

SARAH: Picked up in a bar.

RON: No. I mean, I like you, Sarah, I really do. And I didn't just pick you up in a bar, you know that. We've gotten to be friends, you and me.

SARAH: You want to sleep with me? *(still no eye contact)*

RON: Yes. Do you want to sleep with *me*?

SARAH: *(turning away and speaking softly)* Sure I do, but … it's hard to explain. You and me . . . we're real different . . . you're nice, but you don't know what I mean, and that's one of the things that makes you so nice. But we're different. *(suddenly gathering herself and heading toward the door)* Listen I gotta go. I gotta leave now. We can be friends. Okay? *(Sarah leaves in a rush – Ron watches her go, then softly closes the door*

RON: *(to audience)* But that's not the point of my story. I'm trying to tell the story so that I can understand what happened between me and Sarah Cole that summer and early autumn ten years ago. To say we were lovers says very little about what happened; to say we were friends says even less. No, if I'm to understand the whole thing, I have to say the whole thing. What I need to know is whether what happened between me and Sarah Cole was right or wrong. But let me go on with my story.

Sarah appeared at my apartment door the following morning, a Sunday, cool and rainy. She wore a yellow rain slicker and cap and looked more like a disconsolate schoolgirl facing an angry teacher than a grown woman. I invited her inside, and she accepted my invitation. I

What else can I do? I must describe it. I remember that moment of ten years ago as if it occurred ten minutes ago, the newpapers scattered over the couch and floor, the sound of windblown rain washing the sides of the building outside, and the silence of the room, as we stood across from one another and watched, while we

each simultaneously removed our own clothing, my robe, her blouse, my pajama top, her skirt, my pajama bottom . . .

We made love that morning in my bed for long hours that drifted easily into afternoon. And we talked, as people usually do when they spend half a day or half a night in bed together. I told her of my past, named and described the people I had loved and had loved me, my ex-wife in New York, my brother in the Air Force, my father and mother in their condominium in Florida, and I told her of my ambitions and dreams and even confessed some of my fears. She listened patiently and intelligently throughout and talked much less than I.

During the next few weeks we met often and always at my apartment. Then one hot night, a Saturday in August, Sarah suggested that we go out for a drink. *(To Sarah)* Now?"

SARAH: Sure. It's early. What time is it?

RON: Nine-forty-nine.

SARAH: There. See? Besides, Ron, it's Saturday night. Don't you want to go out and dance or something? *(silence for a moment)* You don't want anybody to know about us, do you? Do you? You're ashamed of being seen with me. You'll sleep with me, but you won't go out in public with me.

RON: That's not true, Sarah.

SARAH: You owe me, Ron, you owe me.

RON: I don't know what you're talking about, Sarah. I don't *owe* you anything.

SARAH: Friendship you owe me. And respect. Friendship and respect. A person can't do what you've done with me without owing them friendship and respect.

RON: Sarah, I really don't know what you're talking about. I am your friend, you know that. And I respect you. I really do.

SARAH: You really think so, don't you? *(silence, then a sigh and in an almost inaudible voice)* Then you'll have to go out in public with me. Maybe well even go to a couple of parties, because *I* get invited to parties sometimes, you know. I have friends, and I have some family, too, and you're gonna have to meet my family. *(voice gradually rising until she was almost shouting)* My kids you're gonna have to meet them. And sometimes you're gonna come over and spend the evening at my place! You *owe* that to me. Or else you're a bad man. It's that simple.

RON: *(to audience)* It was. *(scene change- Intentional shift to 3rd person)* The handsome man is over-dressed. Everyone else is dressed appropriately - jeans and cowboy boots, tee shirts with catchy sayings printed across the front. The man doesn't know anyone, but the woman knows most of the people there, and she gladly introduces him. The woman does most of the talking for everyone. She chats and rambles aimlessly through loud monologues, laughs uproariously at trivial jokes, and drinks too much, until soon she is drunk, thick-tongued, clumsy, and the man has to say her goodbyes and ease her out the door to his car and drive her home to her apartment.

This happens twice in one week, and then three times the next. Ron no longer calls Sarah when he gets home from work; he waits for her call, and sometimes, when he knows it's she, he doesn't answer the phone. Usually, he lets it ring five or six times, and then he reaches down and picks up the receiver. *(to Sarah)* Hello?

SARAH: *(in a flat voice) We should talk.*

RON: *(to audience)* The woman arrives at Ron's apartment. It's a warm evening, and she's wearing her white bermuda shorts, a pink sleeveless sweater, and shower sandals. Ron hates those clothes. He hates the way the shorts cut into her flesh at the crotch and thigh, hates the large, dark caves below her arms that get exposed by the sweater, hates the flapping noise made by the sandals.

Shortly, there is a soft knock at his door. He opens it, turns away. He invites her to sit down. *(to Sarah)* Well, you wanted to talk.

SARAH: Yes. But now you're mad at me. I can see that. I didn't do anything, Ron. (long pause and a sign) You don't want to see me anymore, do you?

RON: Yes. That's right.

SARAH: *(in a low voice)* You're a son of a bitch. You're worse than my ex-husband. *(smiling meanly)* You think I'm just so much meat, and all you got to do is call up the butcher shop and cancel your order. Well, now you're going to find out different. You *can't* cancel your order. I'm not meat, I'm not one of your pretty little girlfriends who come running when you want them and go away when you get tired of them. I'm *different*. I got nothing to lose, Ron. Nothing. You're stuck with me, Ron.

RON: *(through clinched teeth)* Enough is enough. I've given you enough. *(to audience)* Ron orders her to leave. She refuses. He grabs her by the arm and yanks her to her feet. He stands back and places his fists on his hips and looks at her. *(to Sarah)* Go on and leave, you ugly bitch. *(to audience).* And then she is gone, and he is alone again. Perhaps I should admit, since we are nearing the end of my story, that I don't actually know that Sarah Cole is dead. People said Sarah moved back with her ex-husband and was living in a trailer in a park . . .

When someone you have loved dies, you accept the fact of his or her death, but then the person goes on living in your memory. You have imaginary conversations with him or her, you see something striking and remind yourself to tell your loved one about it and then get brought up short by the knowledge of the fact of his or her death, With Sarah, none of that happened. When she was gone from my life, she was gone absolutely, as if she had never existed in the first place. It was only later, when I could think of her as dead and could come out and say it: "My friend Sarah Cole is dead" -- that I was able to tell this story, for that is when she began

to enter my memories. I learned that I truly did love her, and now I have begun to grieve over her death, to wish her alive again, so that I can say to her the things I could not know or say when she was alive, when I did not know that I loved her.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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